

UCH

...nearly derail the ongoing programme

Truth or Dare

MYTH: Sex education is a new programme which is entirely Western in orientation, introduced as it is in conjunction with UNICEF.

REALITY: It is neither new nor Western. NCERT has been building an adolescent education programme, initially used as a euphemism for sex education, since 1993. The mission was reiterated in the National Curriculum Framework, 2005, which said its main objective was to empower adolescents towards their "reproductive and sexual health concerns". This was echoed in the National Focus Group on Health and Physical Education.

MYTH: The modules are too graphic for students, especially in the life skills packages for Class IX.

REALITY: Graphic they may be, but these are meant only as toolkits for teachers, to be used and amended as locally required. Children are not meant to read them.

MYTH: The controversial flip charts are vulgar and obscene, with naked images of men and women detailing changes in the male and female bodies.

REALITY: Perhaps. But the instructions clearly say the sessions using them should be conducted separately for boys and girls, especially if the programme has been recently initiated.

taken a political turn. It's now being perceived as a clash of cultures: the permissive West where subjects like erection and masturbation can be discussed in a classroom, and the regressive East where sex is practised in private and is a taboo in public. Those who initiated it, like the HRD Ministry, which had stated that the main objective of adolescence education was to empower children in respect to their "reproductive and sexual health concerns", have now withdrawn from the debate, leaving the field open for half-truths and semi-facts to be propounded by politicians. Despite repeated attempts to contact them, the secretary, HRD Ministry, refused to respond to the controversy.

The fact is that even UNAIDS acknowledges the material sent out by UNICEF "needed to be reviewed" and specifically that the material was never intended for students. National coordinator, AEP, J.L. Pandey, is more pointed. "While there is a need for detailed explanations in cosmopolitan schools, we cannot have a one-size-fits-all material for the whole of India." By the time, two months ago, the HRD Ministry wrote to all states saying the "prototypes" should

be reviewed in the socio-cultural context of the state, the damage had already been done. The tone of argument had become shrill on both sides—the right wing fundamentalists and the AIDS activists. While UNAIDS has dubbed the outcry as a conspiracy of the fundamentalist fringe, the AIDS activists have agonised over vulnerable adolescents, easy preys to both sexual disease and abuse in the age of easy-to-google porn and easier-to-transmit MMSes.

The problem, however, remains that little of the material they have drafted can be of any use to the population most sensitive to such assault. In a nation where despite increasing openness in the media, sex is still a matter of hushed whispers and awkward giggles in schools and at homes; in-your-face explanation is not the need of the hour. Take this: the Life Skills

Modules for Class IX puts in a myth and reality format a number of facts like vasectomy decreases the sexual desire of the man, or that circumcision increases the virility or sexual power of a man, or the nature of an erection. The NCERT package is not that detailed. The difference can be perceived even in the way the images are displayed—in contrast to NCERT's modestly clothed men and women, the images in the flip charts are flagrantly undressed.

But as R. Govinda, professor, National University of Educational Planning and Administration, puts it: "It is not a matter of why there should be sex education, but how it should be conducted." Such a realistic stand is not ac-

ceptable to certain rigid elements who have forced chief ministers in several states to ask for the programme to be scrapped—Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh and Rajasthan in particular. In Chhattisgarh, there is no formal decision, although the chief minister has called the officials from the ministry and asked them to wait. Though UNAIDS would like to see this as a right-wing movement, Kerala and Maharashtra's objections indicate that the resistance is not

just a question of which party is ruling the state. In Kerala, opposition came only after the course materials were translated into Malayalam by the Education Department this year, though the scheme was on since 2005 but was never inducted in the curriculum. Kerala Education Minister M.A. Baby insists: "The first wrong thing was to dub adolescent education as sex education." He says the state had no option but to suspend the programme when it was petitioned by various social interest groups.

In Maharashtra, currently ruled by the Congress, the Government instructed CBSE to drop the AEP and asked schools to discontinue sex education. As Minister of State for School Education Hassan Mushrif says: "We had hoped that sex education would be of great help to children between 13



"WHY SHOULD WE IMPART WESTERN SEX EDUCATION? OUR VALUES ARE GOOD ENOUGH."

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